DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Is There Evil in the World?

Daat Tevunot, Summary

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** Summary of Sections 1-2 (the English edition's short summaries, page 653) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 17 April 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Back after Pesah

The first class of the summer term, now at 6.45 with Minhah at 7.15. Since we are near the end of Section 5, the Rabbi used the very short summaries at the back of the English edition (page 653) to review everything, before returning to the text.

The introduction and the purpose of creation

The book's theme is to clarify how God runs the world with perfect justice, directing it towards the messianic era and eternal existence, so that our faith and ability to serve Him will be strengthened.

God wanted to bestow the greatest possible good on man. The ultimate good is closeness to God, the source of all good. So He made us imperfect, with the task of perfecting ourselves and the world, so that we could earn great merit and come as close as possible to Him in the future world of reward. He made the world imperfect by concealing His infinite essence. "This is the whole Derech Hashem, in short."

God's oneness

The centre of the whole book is Yihud Hashem, gilui yihudo, the revelation of God's oneness. All of world history leads towards it. God's oneness means not only that there is one God and that He alone exists necessarily, while everything else exists only because He wills it. It means that there is no power in the world except His, and nothing can oppose His will.

The Rabbi called this "a huge challenge". This is why we cover our eyes for Shema Yisrael, why we repeat it morning and evening, and why Jews have died with Shema Yisrael on their lips. We see things in the world we do not understand, and still we say Hashem is one and nothing goes against His will. As the Ramhal explains in Derech Hashem, we cover our eyes because we believe it in our minds but cannot see it.

The purpose and the means

The summary distinguishes purpose from means. The purpose of creation is to bestow goodness by giving man the task of perfecting a world of good and evil. The means God chose was to make all of existence depend on the revelation of His oneness.

The revelation of His oneness requires the temporary existence of evil and its eventual destruction. Evil looks like a power of its own, and the realisation that it has none reveals that there is no power but His. So there are two phases: when evil exists, the 6,000 years of history; and when it is destroyed, leaving a wholly good world, Olam Haba.

So why is there evil?

The Rabbi asked the class: if someone asks you why there is evil if there is a God, what do you answer? Two answers came: to meet the challenge of evil and perfect ourselves, and to reveal God's oneness. Both are correct, he said, and they are linked. When I see something that seems to go against Hashem and could bring me pleasure, and I say no, because if I truly believe in Yihud Hashem I cannot gain anything against His will, I perfect myself and reveal His oneness at the same time.

Which is the ultimate goal? At first the Rabbi said perfecting ourselves, with the revelation as the means. A participant argued the reverse. By the end of the class the Rabbi said he had made a mistake: the Ramhal states clearly in Section 2 that Yihud Hashem is important in and of itself. The participant was right, he said: "the ultimate is the revelation of Hashem's oneness." The means is our choice between good and bad.

Two kinds of evil, and the hands of others

A participant mentioned people who suffer at the hands of others. The Rabbi said this is a separate subject that the Ramhal does not really address in this book. That is about human free will. He quoted Rabbi Sacks: when asked "where was God during the Holocaust?", he answered "where was man during the Holocaust?" If I could not harm you when I chose to, I would not have free will. God allowed free will; He did not intend each harm.

The book deals with two kinds of evil: evil God brings on the world, such as tragedies and disasters, and the evil of temptation, things that look alluring. Why does someone eat non-kosher food he knows is forbidden? Because he loves the taste. If he recognised that there is something far "tastier", the true pleasure of devekut, he could overcome it.

Time to think

But do we think of this in the moment? Usually not, and that, said the Rabbi, is the root. He cited the Ramhal's Mesillat Yesharim: the greatest source of sin is not having time to think. When Moshe first asked Pharaoh for a three-day festival, Pharaoh answered, "Let the work be heavier on the men... and let them not pay attention to false words." Pharaoh understood: if they have time to ask for a holiday, they still think, and a slave who thinks of freedom is not fully enslaved. This is zehirut, vigilance. "This is why it's important we have to remind ourselves."

Revelation comes in levels

A participant pointed out that everything has a range of levels. The Rabbi agreed: this is why Hazal speak of one-sixtieth, as in Shabbat being one-sixtieth of Olam Haba and sleep one-sixtieth of death, just as one-sixtieth of milk in meat is there but cannot be tasted. Even now we can glimpse some revelation, which strengthens us.

He disliked predictions that Mashiah will come "this year". It is a process. Already a century ago the Hafes Hayim said we live in the "footsteps of Mashiah", and 1948 was a major step. The era of Mashiah is still within the 6,000 years: Jewish sovereignty and a Jewish leader, but we still have bodies and temptations. It is only a beginning. Full revelation comes after 6,000, in stages.

He added that the redemption could have come any time after the destruction of the second Temple. Rabbi Akiva believed Bar Kokhba was Mashiah because he was winning battles, until he was killed. Some academics suggest the deaths of Rabbi Akiva's students were connected to internal conflict over Bar Kokhba. The Rabbi compared the trauma of that failure to what followed Shabtai Sevi, and to more recent disappointed messianic hopes.

Adam and the tree

The summary ends: Adam could have brought about the revelation of God's oneness through recognising that anything against God's will is false. The tree was "good to eat, a delight to the eyes"; it appealed to all the senses, as temptations do. Instead he sinned, denying God's oneness, and so man must experience the full force of evil through the 6,000 years, until God destroys it and man sees that it never had any power.

Summary

- The purpose of creation is to bestow good on man through his own effort; the means is the revelation of God's oneness.
- Yihud Hashem means no power exists except God's; we cover our eyes at Shema because we believe it without seeing it.
- Evil exists temporarily in order to be overcome and destroyed, revealing that it never had power.
- The Rabbi concluded that the ultimate goal is the revelation of His oneness, achieved through our choices.
- Sin comes from not stopping to think; revelation and redemption come gradually, not in a single predicted year.

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